

VPN Troubleshooting Guide

Diagnosis, safe recovery steps, escalation, and user communication

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Important: Northstar Digital Services is a fictional company created solely for RAG, document retrieval, citation, and corporate AI training exercises. These procedures are illustrative and are not instructions for any real organization.

1. Purpose and scope

This guide helps Northstar Digital Services (NDS) employees and first-line IT support diagnose common problems connecting to the company virtual private network (VPN). It covers connection failures, repeated disconnections, authentication errors, and limited access after a successful connection. It applies to company-managed Windows and macOS devices using the fictional NDS SecureConnect client.

2. Before troubleshooting

- Confirm the employee is using a company-managed or explicitly approved device.
- Record the approximate time the issue began, the device operating system, the VPN client version, and the exact error message.
- Ask whether the issue affects one user, several users on the same network, or many users across locations.
- Check the fictional NDS service-status page through the normal internal portal, if available.
- Do not ask the employee to share their password, one-time passcode, recovery code, private key, or session token.

3. Common symptoms and likely causes

Symptom	Possible causes	Initial check
Cannot connect	No internet, outdated client, service outage, blocked network	Open an approved public/internal site; check service status
Repeated disconnections	Unstable Wi-Fi, device sleep, network handoff, client issue	Test a stable approved network; note disconnect time
Authentication failed	Expired password, account lock, MFA issue, incorrect account	Check account status using approved identity workflow
Connected but cannot reach an app	Missing permissions, DNS/routing issue, app outage	Check whether other approved internal services work
Very slow connection	Weak Wi-Fi, high latency, overloaded endpoint, large downloads	Compare with normal network performance and service status

4. Standard troubleshooting procedure

Step 1 — Verify internet access

Open an approved website or internal service without the VPN, if company policy allows. If the device has no internet connection, resolve the local network issue first or contact the network provider/help desk.

Step 2 — Inspect the connection

Confirm the device is not in airplane mode, the selected Wi-Fi or wired network is stable, and the device date and time are correct. Avoid changing advanced network settings without authorization.

Step 3 — Reconnect once

Disconnect SecureConnect, wait approximately 10 seconds, and reconnect. Read any displayed error carefully and record its exact wording. Avoid repeated rapid connection attempts.

Step 4 — Check client status

Confirm the approved VPN client is running and that the device is using the currently supported version. If an update is offered, follow the company-managed software update process.

Step 5 — Restart only when appropriate

Save work and restart the VPN client if permitted. Restart the computer only if the issue persists and the user can safely close applications. Do not uninstall security software or disable endpoint protection.

Step 6 — Test the scope

If permitted, determine whether the problem occurs on another approved network. Do not use public Wi-Fi or a personal hotspot if company policy prohibits it.

Step 7 — Escalate

If the issue persists after the approved checks, create an IT ticket with the information listed in Section 6.

5. Authentication and multi-factor authentication (MFA)

- If the account is locked or a password has expired, use the approved identity portal or contact the service desk.
- If an MFA prompt is unexpected, repeated, or initiated by someone else, deny it and report the event through the security reporting process.
- Never approve an MFA prompt that you did not initiate. Never send an MFA code to a support person in chat or email.
- Do not attempt to bypass conditional access, device compliance, or identity verification controls.

6. Information to include in an IT ticket

- Employee username or internal employee identifier, submitted only through the approved ticketing system.
- Device asset tag, operating system and version, VPN client version.
- Date/time and time zone of each failure; exact error text or screenshot with sensitive data removed.
- Network type (office, home, or approved remote network) and whether other services work.
- Troubleshooting steps already completed and whether the issue affects other users.
- Business impact and a safe time to contact the employee.

7. Escalation matrix

Priority	Example	Action
P1 — Critical	Widespread VPN outage blocking a major business function	Contact the incident manager and network on-call team immediately
P2 — High	Multiple users or a critical team unable to connect	Route to network operations; include affected sites and start time
P3 — Normal	One user affected with a workaround available	Create a standard service ticket with diagnostics
Security concern	Unexpected MFA prompts, suspected credential theft, suspicious client behavior	Use the security incident process immediately; do not wait for routine troubleshooting

8. Frequently asked questions

Why does VPN disconnect when I close my laptop lid?

The device may enter sleep mode and interrupt the network tunnel. Follow approved power-management guidance; do not alter centrally managed settings without IT approval.

Can I disable endpoint protection to make the VPN work?

No. Do not disable antivirus, endpoint detection, firewall, or other security controls. Escalate the issue to IT.

The VPN says connected, but an internal application is unavailable. Is the VPN broken?

Not necessarily. The application may be down, or access permissions, name resolution, or routing may be involved. Record which services are reachable and open a ticket.

What if I receive repeated MFA requests?

Deny unexpected requests and report them to the security team immediately.

How long should I retry?

Try the standard reconnect procedure once or twice at most. Repeated rapid attempts can make diagnosis harder; record the error and escalate.

9. Support checklist

- ■ Internet connectivity checked
- ■ Exact error and time recorded
- ■ One controlled reconnect attempted
- ■ VPN client status/version checked
- ■ No security controls disabled
- ■ Ticket includes scope, impact and troubleshooting history